

CONFIDENTIAL REPORT: STRATEGIC RECRUITMENT INTELLIGENCE 2025-2026

PREPARED EXCLUSIVELY FOR: Nicole Rayment, Principal Owner / Trainer, Pleasure Island Design LLC **CLASSIFICATION:** TOP SECRET // INTERNAL USE ONLY **DATE:** December 2, 2025 **SUBJECT:** Comprehensive Analysis of Recruitment Vectors for Skilled Labor & Supervisory Roles

WATERMARK: TOP SECRET // PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // CONFIDENTIAL

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. **Executive Intelligence Summary**
 - The 2025 Labor Landscape in North Carolina
 - The Pleasure Island Design Identity & Recruitment Mission
 - The "Blue Collar" Reality: Heavy Lifting & High Standards
2. **Strategic Asset: Local Government & Educational Resources**
 - NCWorks Online: The Hidden Government Pipeline
 - Cape Fear Community College: Tapping the Source
 - Unemployment & Re-Employment Vectors
3. **Option 1: Indeed – The Heavy Artillery**
 - Deep Dive: The Algorithm & Auction Model
 - Cost Analysis: Sponsored Jobs vs. Free Posts
 - Tactical Execution: Filtering for the "75lb Standard"
4. **Option 2: ZipRecruiter – The Rapid Response Unit**
 - Technology Focus: AI Matching & "Phil"
 - The "Auto-Renewal" Trap: Financial Pitfalls
 - Mobile Optimization for the Modern Laborer
5. **Option 3: Craigslist – The Local Insurgent**
 - Why "Old School" Works for Coastal NC
 - Pricing Models for Wilmington & Vicinity
 - Safety Protocols & Scam Avoidance
6. **Option 4: LinkedIn – The Headhunter's Scope (Foreman Specific)**
 - Why It Fails for Laborers but Wins for Leaders
 - Brand Leverage: Selling "Affordable Luxury" to Managers
 - Recruiter Lite vs. Standard: Value Analysis
7. **Option 5: iHireConstruction – The Niche Specialist**
 - Quality Over Quantity: The Trade-Off
 - Resume Database Effectiveness
8. **"Out of the Box" Solutions & Guerrilla Tactics**
 - BoomNation: The "Instagram" of Trades
 - Hyper-Local Community Engagement (Facebook/Nextdoor)
 - The Job Site "Poach" & Supplier Networking

9. The Hiring Toolkit: Templates & Protocols

- Job Description Architectures (Labor vs. Foreman)
- The "Red Flag" Interview Checklist
- Onboarding & Retention: Keeping the Crew

10. Final Recommendations & Implementation Roadmap

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // STRATEGIC GROWTH INITIATIVE

1. EXECUTIVE INTELLIGENCE SUMMARY

The 2025 Labor Landscape in North Carolina

The construction and skilled trades sector in North Carolina is entering a critical phase in the 2025-2026 period. The state ranks as the 5th strongest construction market in the United States, driven by a surge in residential demand and infrastructure projects. This strength creates a double-edged sword for employers: while business is booming, the competition for labor is fiercer than ever.

Wages in the sector have risen approximately 11.4% over the last three years, trailing slightly behind the explosive 22.3% wage growth seen across all NC occupations. This discrepancy means that skilled workers are often tempted to leave the trades for less physically demanding roles in logistics or retail unless the "total package"—pay, culture, and stability—is compelling. For **Pleasure Island Design (PID)**, the challenge is distinct. You are not pouring concrete for a highway; you are delivering "affordable luxury" in client-occupied homes. This requires a hybrid employee: someone with the brute strength to carry 75lbs of cabinetry up stairs, but the finesse and "soft skills" to work cleanly in a high-end kitchen without disrupting the homeowner's life.

The PID Identity & Recruitment Mission

Your brand is built on "Transformation without Disruption." You offer a premium service that feels like a magic trick to the client—a new kitchen in 5-8 days. Your recruitment process must mirror this efficiency.

- **The Goal:** Hire skilled laborers (finish carpentry, sanding, prep) and a Working Foreman (site management, client relations).
- **The Constraint:** High School comprehension level for all materials (accessibility is key), focus on "Blue Collar" realities (sweat equity, reliability), and a strict budget consciousness.
- **The "Top Secret" Edge:** Most competitors use a "post and pray" method. This report outlines a "sniper" approach—targeting specific pools of talent with precision to minimize wasted ad spend and maximize retention.

The "Blue Collar" Reality: Heavy Lifting & High Standards

We must be brutally honest in our recruitment marketing. A role at PID is not for everyone.

- **The Physicality:** The requirement to lift 75lbs is not a suggestion; it is a daily operational necessity.
- **The Hours:** Construction schedules are dictated by project completion, often requiring long days to meet the "5-8 day" turnaround promise.
- **The Vetting:** Finding a foreman who can sand a cabinet *and* soothe a nervous client is

rare.

This report analyzes five primary channels to find these specific individuals, grading them on cost, speed, and quality.

FOOTER: BEST PRACTICE: HIRE SLOW, FIRE FAST. SAFETY FIRST.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // GOVERNMENT ASSETS

2. STRATEGIC ASSET: LOCAL GOVERNMENT & EDUCATIONAL RESOURCES

Before allocating budget to commercial entities, PID must exploit the resources subsidized by tax dollars. These are often overlooked by competitors but offer the highest ROI (Return on Investment) because the initial cash cost is near zero.

NCWorks Online: The Hidden Government Pipeline

What is it? NCWorks is the official labor exchange system for North Carolina. It is not just a website; it is an integrated workforce development ecosystem connecting employers with job seekers.

Why it matters for 2025: Individuals claiming unemployment benefits in North Carolina are generally required to register with NCWorks and actively search for employment. This creates a captive audience of available labor.

The "Employer Services" Suite: The NCWorks Career Centers (including the Cape Fear region offices) offer a "concierge" service for businesses at no direct cost.

Feature	Description for PID	Value
Candidate Screening	You provide the job description (must lift 75lbs, cabinet experience). State employees screen applicants and send you only the qualified ones.	High (Saves time)
Tax Credits (WOTC)	The Work Opportunity Tax Credit allows you to claim federal tax credits for hiring veterans, long-term unemployed, or justice-involved individuals.	Financial (Up to \$9,600)
Fidelity Bonding	Free insurance bonds (up to \$5,000+) provided by the state to protect you against theft/dishonesty if you hire "at-risk" applicants (e.g., those with a criminal record but great hands).	Risk Mitigation
OJT (On-the-Job Training)	Potential reimbursement of 50-75% of a new hire's wages for a set period (e.g., 3-6 months) to compensate for the	Subsidized Wages

Feature	Description for PID	Value
	cost of training them in your specific refinishing systems.	

How to Use It:

1. **Register:** Go to www.ncworks.gov and create an employer account.
2. **Contact:** Do not just post online. Call the **Cape Fear NCWorks Career Center** (910-251-5777) and ask for a "Business Services Representative." Tell them you are a local woman-owned business in Carolina Beach looking to hire.
3. **Specify:** Be explicit about the physical requirements. "We need people who can work with their hands and carry heavy loads. We are willing to train the right attitude."

Cape Fear Community College (CFCC): Tapping the Source

The Opportunity: CFCC is a hub for trade education in Wilmington. They run specific programs for **Construction Management**, **Carpentry**, and **General Construction**.

Targeting the Foreman: The Construction Management program produces graduates trained in estimating, scheduling, and leadership. These are prime candidates for your "Working Foreman" role. They have the book smarts but need the field experience PID offers.

Targeting the Laborer: The "Construction Bootcamp" and "Carpentry" courses produce entry-level workers who have already demonstrated an interest in the field and have learned basic safety.

Action Plan:

- **Direct Liaison:** Contact **Tyler Gemmell**, Program Director for Construction Management.
 - *Email:* jtgemmell849@cfcc.edu
 - *Phone:* 910-362-7658
- **The Pitch:** "I am Nicole Rayment, owner of Pleasure Island Design. We do high-end finish work. I am looking for a graduate who wants to master the 'finishing' side of construction, not just framing."
- **Career Services:** Post jobs directly on their internal board via the "Handshake" platform used by students.

Unemployment & Re-Employment Vectors

The Portal: When North Carolinians file for unemployment, they use the **DES (Division of Employment Security)** portal. This data feeds into NCWorks. By posting on NCWorks, you are effectively putting your job ad in front of every person currently collecting a check who needs to prove they are looking for work.

Pitfalls:

- **Compliance Applications:** You may get applications from people just "checking a box" to keep their benefits.
- **Filtering:** Use the screening questions heavily. "Do you have reliable transportation to Pleasure Island?" is a great filter.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // COMMERCIAL OPTION 1

3. OPTION 1: INDEED – THE HEAVY ARTILLERY

Verdict: The Primary Engine for Volume. **Best For:** General Laborers, Crew Members,

Apprentices.

Deep Dive: The Mechanics

Indeed is the "Google" of jobs. It aggregates listings from everywhere but prioritizes direct posts. In 2025, it operates on a sophisticated **Pay-for-Performance** model. It uses an auction system where employers bid for visibility.

Cost & Pricing Tiers

Indeed has moved away from simple "per post" fees to a dynamic budget model.

Tier	Cost Structure	Estimated Price (NC Market)	Features
Free Post	\$0.00	Free	Loses visibility after 48-72 hours. Buried by sponsored ads. Good for testing the waters.
Sponsored (Standard)	Pay-Per-Click (PPC)	\$15 - \$20 / day budget	Your ad stays at the top. You pay when someone clicks to view.
Sponsored (Matched)	Pay-Per-Application	\$15 - \$50 / applicant	You only pay for applicants who meet your "deal breaker" criteria.

Hidden Costs:

- **The "Optimize" Trap:** Indeed will suggest "Optimizing your budget" to get more candidates. This usually means raising your daily spend to \$50+. Ignore this unless you are desperate.
- **Resume Subscription:** They will try to sell you access to their resume database (~\$100-\$200/mo). **Avoid this.** Blue-collar workers rarely update their resumes unless they are actively applying.

Terms & Conditions: The "Deal Breaker" Clause

This is the most critical feature for PID. Indeed allows you to set "Deal Breaker" questions.

- *Example:* "Can you lift 75lbs?"
- *Rule:* If a candidate answers "No," they are marked as "Rejected."
- *The Catch:* If you use the Pay-Per-Application model, you **must** manually reject these candidates within a specific window (usually 72 hours) or Indeed **will charge you for them anyway**. You cannot "set it and forget it."

Best Practices & Tips

- **Title Strategy:** Use standard titles. "Construction Laborer" gets 10x more traffic than "Renovation Specialist."
- **Mobile First:** 75% of Indeed traffic is mobile. Ensure your application does *not* require a custom cover letter. That is a barrier to entry for a guy applying from his truck on a lunch

break.

- **The "Urgent" Badge:** If you sponsor a job, you can sometimes add an "Urgently Hiring" tag. This increases click-through rates by signaling you will hire fast.

Success Rates & Effectiveness

- **Volume:** High. You will get 20-30 applications in a week.
- **Quality:** Variable. Expect 50% to be unqualified or live too far away.
- **Speed:** Very fast. You can have an interview scheduled within 24 hours of posting.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // COMMERCIAL OPTION 2

4. OPTION 2: ZIPRECRUITER – THE RAPID RESPONSE UNIT

Verdict: Speed over Precision. Expensive but fast. **Best For:** When you need a crew member *tomorrow*.

Technology Focus: AI Matching & "Phil"

ZipRecruiter differentiates itself with AI technology (branded as "Phil"). Instead of waiting for candidates to search for you, ZipRecruiter:

1. **Scrapes** millions of resumes and profiles.
2. **Identifies** candidates who match your keywords ("Cabinetry," "Construction," "Wilmington").
3. **Proactively Invites** them to apply via email and push notification.

Pros: This reaches "passive" candidates—people who have a profile but aren't searching today.

Cons: It can feel spammy to candidates, leading to people applying just to stop the notifications.

Cost & Pricing Tiers

ZipRecruiter is one of the pricier options for small businesses.

Plan Tier	Pricing (Est.)	Features
Standard	\$16 - \$24 / day (Daily Plan)	Distributes to 100+ job boards. Basic visibility.
Monthly	\$299+ / month (Subscription)	1 Active Job Slot. Includes some "TrafficBoost" credits.
TrafficBoost	\$60 - \$100 / boost	A one-time injection to push your ad to the top of emails.

Hidden Costs & The "Auto-Renewal" Trap:

- **Warning:** ZipRecruiter is notorious for its "Free Trial" mechanics. If you sign up for a 4-day free trial, you **must** cancel before the clock runs out.
- **The Pitfall:** Many users report that cancelling requires a phone call during business hours, or navigating a complex menu. If you miss the window, you are charged for the full month (\$299+). There are virtually no refunds.
- **Recommendation:** Use a "virtual" credit card (like Privacy.com) with a strict spending limit if you sign up for a trial, so they cannot charge you if you forget.

Best Practices & Tips

- **The "Invite to Apply" Button:** As an employer, you can swipe through candidates. If you click "Thumbs Up," the system sends a pre-written message from Nicole: *"I saw your profile and think you'd be great for PID..."* This personal touch works very well for foremen.
- **One-Click Apply:** This is great for volume but bad for filtering. You will get applicants who didn't read the "75lb" requirement. You must screen them over the phone immediately.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // COMMERCIAL OPTION 3

5. OPTION 3: CRAIGSLIST – THE LOCAL INSURGENT

Verdict: The Best Value for Coastal/Island Labor. **Best For:** Local Laborers, Part-Timers, Handymen.

Why "Old School" Works for Coastal NC

Craigslist remains a dominant force in the trades. Older, experienced carpenters (Gen X and Boomers) trust it. Furthermore, it is hyper-local. A worker living in Kure Beach or Carolina Beach often checks Craigslist to find work *on the island* to avoid the bridge traffic to Wilmington.

Pricing Models for Wilmington & Vicinity

- **Cost:** Craigslist charges a flat fee per job post in the "Jobs" section.
- **Wilmington/Cape Fear Area:** Approximately **\$25 - \$35 per post**.
- **Duration:** The post stays live for 30 days.

Comparison: \$35 for 30 days is significantly cheaper than Indeed (\$15/day = \$450/month) or ZipRecruiter (\$299/month).

Safety Protocols & Scam Avoidance

Craigslist is the "Wild West." There is no vetting.

- **The "Check" Scam:** If an applicant asks to send you a check for "equipment" before they start, it is a scam.
- **Safety:** Never conduct the first interview at your home office or a client's home. Meet at a public coffee shop (e.g., Malama Cafe) or a neutral, busy job site.
- **The "Flake" Factor:** Expect 50% of scheduled interviews to be no-shows.
 - *Tip:* Schedule "Block Interviews." Tell three candidates to come between 8:00 AM and 9:00 AM. Whoever shows up gets the interview.

Best Practices

- **Headline Strategy:** "WORK ON THE ISLAND - NO BRIDGE COMMUTE - Cabinet Crew." This is your strongest selling point.
- **Photos:** Include a photo of a finished PID kitchen. Show them the *quality* of work they will be doing. Good tradesmen take pride in their craft.

- **Call to Action:** "Text Nicole at [Number]." Do not use the email relay if you want speed. Texting is the language of construction.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // COMMERCIAL OPTION 4

6. OPTION 4: LINKEDIN – THE HEADHUNTER’S SCOPE

Verdict: The Surgical Tool for Leadership. **Best For:** Working Foreman, Project Manager, Superintendent.

Why It Fails for Laborers but Wins for Leaders

General laborers do not maintain LinkedIn profiles. However, construction professionals who aspire to management (Foremen, Site Supers) do. They use LinkedIn to network and showcase their project portfolios.

Cost & Pricing

- **Job Posting:** You can usually post **one job for free**.
- **Promoted Jobs:** operates on a PPC model, often **\$1.50 - \$4.00 per click**. It is more expensive than Indeed because the audience is "white collar" or "management."
- **Recruiter Lite:** A subscription (~\$170/mo) that lets you message people you aren't connected with.

Brand Leverage: Selling "Affordable Luxury"

For a Foreman, you are selling a *career*, not a gig.

- **The Profile:** Ensure Nicole Rayment's personal LinkedIn profile is professional. It should feature the "Neighborhood Fave" awards and photos of high-end work.
- **The Pitch:** "Join the #1 Cabinet Refinishing Team in Carolina Beach. We are a woman-owned business bringing affordable luxury to the coast. We need a leader."

Recruiter Lite vs. Standard: Value Analysis

- **Recommendation:** Do **NOT** buy Recruiter Lite. It is overkill for a small business hiring one person.
- **Alternative:** Use the free search bar. Search "Construction Foreman" + "Wilmington NC." Connect with them personally. Send a note: *"Hi [Name], I own PID in Carolina Beach. Impressed by your background. We're looking for a working foreman. Open to a coffee?"* This costs \$0.00.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // COMMERCIAL OPTION 5

7. OPTION 5: iHIRECONSTRUCTION – THE NICHE SPECIALIST

Verdict: High Quality, Low Volume. **Best For:** Specialists (Cabinet Makers, Finish Carpenters).

Quality Over Quantity

iHireConstruction (and similar sites like ConstructionJobs.com) is a niche board. It filters out the noise. You won't get teenagers looking for summer jobs or retail workers. You get career tradespeople.

Pricing Tiers

- **Single Slot:** Approx **\$299 - \$349 per month**.
- **Resume Search:** Often an add-on cost.

Effectiveness

- **Success Rate:** You will get fewer applications (maybe 3-5 a month), but they will likely be 90% qualified.
- **Guarantee:** Some plans offer a guarantee that if you don't find a hire, they extend your post. Check the fine print on the specific package.

When to use: Only if Indeed fails to produce a *skilled* foreman. For general labor, it is too expensive.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // UNCONVENTIONAL WARFARE

8. "OUT OF THE BOX" SOLUTIONS & GUERRILLA TACTICS

You asked for creative solutions. In 2025, the best hires often don't come from job boards.

BoomNation: The "Instagram" of Trades

What is it? BoomNation is a mobile app built specifically for blue-collar workers. It functions like a social network where welders, carpenters, and operators post photos of their work. It has a built-in job board.

Why it fits PID: Your business is visual. Cabinet refinishing is an art.

- **The Strategy:** Create a PID profile. Post "Before & After" photos of your best kitchen transformations. Use hashtags like #Cabinetry #WilmingtonConstruction #FinishCarpentry.
- **Recruiting:** When you see a local user posting clean, high-quality work, message them directly.
- **Cost:** \$100/month flat fee for employers. A low-risk experiment.

Hyper-Local Community Engagement

The "Island" Strategy:

- **Facebook Groups:** "Carolina Beach Locals," "Pleasure Island Community," "Island Moms."
- **The Angle:** Do not post a boring "Help Wanted" ad. Post a story.

- *Script:* "Hey neighbors! Nicole from Pleasure Island Design here. We are incredibly blessed to be so busy transforming kitchens on the island. We need to grow our local crew. We're looking for someone strong, reliable, and detailed to help us. Great pay, no bridge traffic. If you know a hard worker looking for a change, tag them!"
- **Cost: Free.**
- **Benefit:** Social proof. Neighbors will tag their nephews, sons, or friends who they *know* are good workers.

The Job Site "Poach" & Supplier Networking

The "Pro Desk" Tactic:

- Go to the **Lowe's Home Improvement** on S College Rd (or the closest Pro desk).
- Talk to the Pro Desk associates (bring them donuts). They know every contractor in town. They know who pays their bills, who shows up early, and who does quality work.
- Ask them: "*Who is a great finish carpenter that might be looking for steady work?*"

The "Business Card" Drop:

- Print cards that say "**PID IS HIRING - SKILLED LABOR**" on the back with a QR code to your application page.
- Leave them at the paint counter at Sherwin-Williams or Benjamin Moore. The best painters are there at 7:00 AM.

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // TACTICAL TOOLKIT

9. THE HIRING TOOLKIT: TEMPLATES & PROTOCOLS

To ensure success, use these templates tailored to the PID brand.

Job Description Architecture: General Laborer

TITLE: Construction Crew / Cabinet Prep - NO BRIDGE COMMUTE (Carolina Beach)

THE MISSION: Pleasure Island Design is the #1 Cabinet Refinishing team in the area. We deliver "affordable luxury" to our neighbors. We need a strong, reliable crew member to help us make magic happen.

THE REALITY (Must Read):

- **Heavy Lifting:** You **MUST** be able to carry 75lbs (cabinet doors, equipment) up and down stairs. This is a gym workout you get paid for.
- **The Grind:** We work hard. We sand, we prep, we clean. It's dusty, active work.
- **The Standard:** We work in occupied luxury homes. No loud music, no swearing, no mess.

THE REWARDS:

- **Pay:** Competitive Hourly (\$XX - \$XX).
- **Location:** Work on Pleasure Island.
- **Growth:** Learn spray finishing and high-end repair techniques.

TO APPLY: Text "PID CREW" and your name to [Phone Number].

Job Description Architecture: Working Foreman

TITLE: Working Foreman / Site Supervisor - High-End Cabinetry

THE ROLE: You are the right hand of the owner. You aren't just watching; you are working. You will lead a 2-3 person crew to transform kitchens in 5-8 days.

REQUIREMENTS:

- **Leadership:** Can you get a crew to show up on time and work efficiently?
- **Craftsmanship:** 3+ years in finishing, painting, or carpentry. You must know how to fix a mistake.
- **Client Skills:** You are the face of PID. You must be able to walk a client through the project with confidence.
- **Tech:** Must be able to use an iPad for schedules and photos.

The "Red Flag" Interview Checklist

Use this during the interview to filter out future headaches.

Observation	Risk Assessment	Pass/Fail
Arrives 5+ mins late without calling	Reliability Risk. Will delay project timelines.	FAIL
Complains about previous boss	Attitude Risk. Will be toxic to crew culture.	FAIL
Cannot verify "75lb" ability	Physical Risk. Liability for injury.	FAIL
Asks for "Cash Only" pay	Legal/Stability Risk.	FAIL
Does not have reliable vehicle	Logistics Risk. You cannot pick them up.	FAIL
Phone goes to voicemail (full)	Communication Risk. How will you reach them?	CAUTION

HEADER: PLEASURE ISLAND DESIGN // ACTION PLAN

10. FINAL RECOMMENDATIONS & IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

The "Top 5" Ranked for PID:

1. **Craigslist:** (Best Value/Local Reach). Post immediately for Laborer role. Focus on "No Bridge Commute."
2. **Indeed:** (Best Volume). Use Sponsored Ads with a strict \$15/day budget. Use screening questions to filter for "75lb lifting."
3. **NCWorks / CFCC:** (Best Hidden Asset). Contact the Community College for an apprentice/intern. Register with the state for tax credits.
4. **LinkedIn:** (Best for Foreman). Passive search only. Don't spend money; spend time networking.
5. **BoomNation:** (The Wildcard). Set up a profile to build a long-term brand among younger tradesmen.

Implementation Checklist (Week 1):

- [] **Day 1:** Register as an employer on **NCWorks.gov**. Call Cape Fear Career Center.
- [] **Day 1:** Post "Laborer" ad on **Craigslist** (\$35). Use the "No Bridge" headline.
- [] **Day 2:** Post "Foreman" ad on **Indeed** (Free first, then \$15/day sponsor if needed). Set

"Deal Breaker" questions.

- [] **Day 3:** Print "We Are Hiring" cards. Drop them at Sherwin-Williams and Lowe's Pro Desk.
- [] **Day 4:** Post a community update photo on **Carolina Beach Locals** Facebook group.

Final Note: The market is tough, but your brand is strong. By leveraging the "local/island" advantage and using government resources to subsidize training, PID can build a crew that meets the "affordable luxury" standard without breaking the bank.

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